

African
Brain
Data
Network

Module 2 - Experimental Design

Stuck? Who can help?

17th of September 2026 - Nicole Vissers



Today's session

Getting stuck is normal!

We can learn to determine:

- What kind of help you need
- Who might be able to help
- How to reach out to them

After today, you will know more about:

- When to ask for help
- Identifying possible resources
- Writing a clear message
- How to interpret their response

Question: What do you do when you get stuck?



- A. Keep trying alone
- B. Search online/tutorials/AI
- C. Ask someone you know
- D. Contact someone you don't know
- E. Move on and come back later



What do you think would be the best response?

Discussion: What does 'stuck' mean to you?





Are we supposed to solve problems alone?

Independence; *“I can figure out what I need”*

Self-sufficiency; *“I have to figure everything out myself”*

Resourcefulness; *“I know how to find the people/resources that can help me”*

In science, resourcefulness is much more useful than self-sufficiency.



You don't need to know everything! You need to know how to find someone who can help!



Discussion: Why don't we ask for help?

“I don't know who to ask”

“I should know this”

“I don't want to bother them”

“They will think my question is stupid”

“They're too busy”

Which barrier feels most familiar?



What to do: Building your support network

You don't need to belong to a lab, have a supervisor, or already know someone to ask for help. You can build a network around the problem you're trying to solve.



Who to reach out to?

Question: Which of these would you feel comfortable contacting? Which would feel uncomfortable? Why?

- **People you know;** colleagues, friends, former teachers
- **People you have met once;** at meetups/conferences
- **People you don't know;** authors, developers, researchers
- **Communities;** online, mailing lists, networks, societies

Activity: Who would you ask for help?

Scenario 1: You cannot reproduce an analysis from a published paper.

- A. A colleague
- B. The paper's first author
- C. A professor you know
- D. The journal editor





Activity: Who would you ask for help?

Scenario 2: You would like to collaborate on a project to publish it together.

- A.** A colleague
- B.** A researcher working on the topic
- C.** A professor you know
- D.** The journal editor



Discussion: Would you email someone you've never met?

Scenario 3: You find a researcher in another country whose work is almost exactly what you want to do. You've never met them.

What makes it appropriate to contact them?

**You don't need to apologise
for contacting someone!**



Ask the right question to the right person

Technical problem: someone with technical expertise

Scientific interpretation: someone with relevant scientific experience

Career decision: experienced researcher/someone you look up to

Access or collaboration: relevant resource or connection

Don't contact the most senior person, but one closest to the problem



When is someone the right person to contact?

You don't need to know someone!

A good reason is enough; their paper, dataset, method, expertise, research question etc.

Make the email as specific as possible

No need to apologize! “I am reaching out because.. ” is better than “Sorry to bother you.. ”



“Science is a collective activity. Other people have knowledge, experience, resources and perspectives that you don't have—and you have things they don't have either.”



What kind of help do you need?

1. **Information**; *“How does this work?”*
2. **Advice**; *“What would you do?”*
3. **Feedback**; *“Does this approach make sense?”*
4. **Expertise**; *“How do I solve this technical problem?”*
5. **Connection**; *“Who else should I speak to?”*
6. **Opportunity**; *“Could there be a way to work together?”*



If you get an email, what message would you prefer:

A. *Dear Sir/Madam, I am having troubles with my analysis. Can you help?*

B. *Dear Sir/Madam, I am trying to reproduce the analysis in your paper. I followed the method in Figure 2, but I get a different result. I have checked X and Y. Could you suggest what I should check next?*

C. *Dear Sir/Madam, I am really interested in your work and I have read all your papers, that's why I am currently trying to do the analysis you have used in your paper. The results are impressive and I was very surprised by X. There is so much to uncover and I keep reading the results and the paper. The topic has already interested me for a while I would love to ask a few questions.*

Requests should be easy to answer

A message should give enough context, but be brief!

Stick to:

Context: Why am I contacting you?

Problem: What am I stuck on?

Effort: What have I already tried?

Question: What specifically would I like from you?



The goal is not to sound impressive, but to make it easy to understand what you need!



Discussion: What do you think about your drafts?

Identify in your draft:

1. Is the right person being contacted?
2. Is the problem specific?
3. Is there enough context?
4. Is the question clear?
5. Easy to answer?

Would you write it differently now?

What if they say no or do not respond?

No response

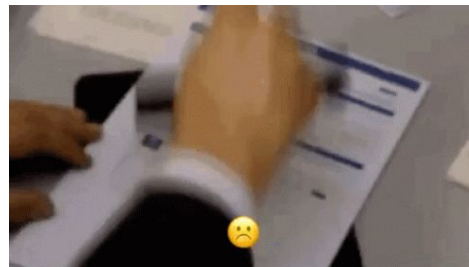
What might it mean?

“I'm too busy.”

What do you do?

“I can't help, but you should contact X.”

What do you do?



These are not rejections!

Challenge:

Are you currently stuck on something?

Determine:

Who might be able to help?

What is the clearest question you could ask them?

When will you reach out?





Summary!

1. Don't confuse independent with doing everything alone
2. Identify the type of help you need
3. Look for the person closest to the problem - not the most senior person
4. Give context; explain what you've tried and make a specific request
5. Follow up once or twice; don't take silence personally
6. Build your network by asking, helping and staying connected!



Other places to ask for help!

- LinkedIn
- Forums: Stackexchange, Reddit, Stackoverflow
- Github
- Slack communities
- Researchgate
- <https://neurostars.org/>

Do make sure the source is credible! And closest to the problem!



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